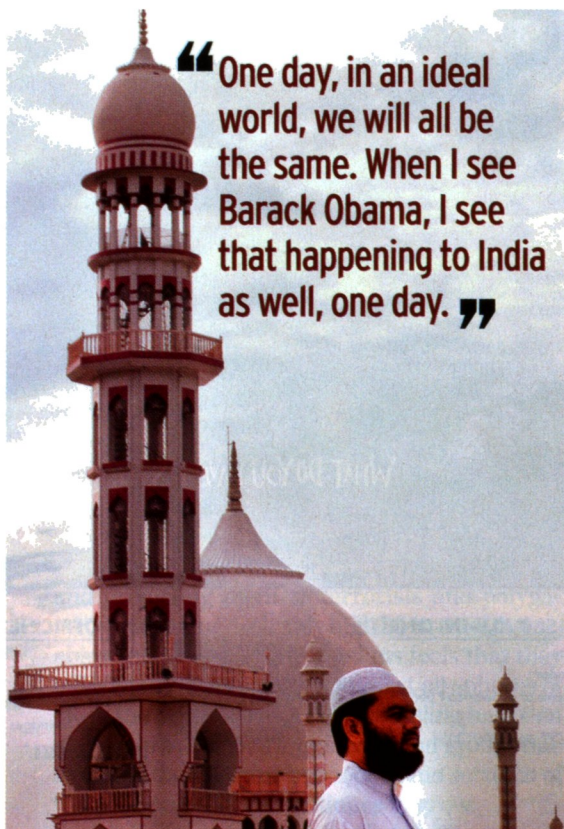


SALMAN KHURSHID

Congress leader

MUSLIM POLITICIAN OF THE LIBERAL HUE IS DYING SLOWLY, SUFFOCATING HIMSELF WITH HELPLESSNESS AND IRRELEVANCE

Everyone must have his own story about how life has treated him or her. So must every Muslim. Obviously, some feel betrayed and have, therefore, taken to doing things that too are a betrayal of others, and the nation. Yet others seem to have found a cause. Bombs are destroying decades of assiduously built bonds. Somewhere, politicians are saying: "We suddenly feel Muslim". The trouble is that many Muslims think we are not Muslim enough—not because of namaz and roza but because we have not suffered like them.



ISHAAN TANKHA

“One day, in an ideal world, we will all be the same. When I see Barack Obama, I see that happening to India as well, one day.”

The truth is that most of us have felt being Muslim at different times in different ways. We have not been discriminated against and, if anything, have benefited from the implicit affirmative action of the Indian State. The Cabinet must have a few Muslim ministers but only a few; every political stage must have a Muslim face but not a crowd. Four Muslims might be one too many, just as four Sikhs or Christians would be, but not four Hindus. But this is not something to fret about. It is inherent in the nature of democracy and majoritarian decision-making. One day, in an ideal world, we will all be the same. When I see Barack Obama, I see that happening to India as well, one day.

As a Muslim and a politician, I share the excitement of being alive in today's India. I may not have a fear of being killed but I cannot be oblivious to those who are dying every day. The real problem is of dying slowly, suffocating himself with helplessness and irrelevance. That is what is happening to Muslim politicians of the liberal hue. Your community thinks you are irrelevant and the rest of the world is surprised that you appear anguished. Closer home the poet said: The narrow-minded has seen me as a *kafir*, non-believer; And the *kafirs* think that I am a *muselman*.

Jamia's vice-chancellor is attacked for offering legal aid to his students held as suspected terrorists. He was once attacked for questioning those who disagreed with Salman Rushdie. In both cases, we did not ask what is liberalism? It is not only something you agree with; it is the right to be wrong. No Muslim leader can grow if someone else chooses what he or she says. No Muslim leader can survive without sharing the feelings of ordinary Muslims. They will not give their trust otherwise. A leaderless community is dangerous just as a leader without followers is a tragedy.